

Holiday Escapes



Mahesh Benkar

Neeraj gets up with a start. "Oh no! It's already 6:30 am. I'll never make it to the reservation counter on time." He pulls on his clothes and dashes out into the cool morning air. The sunrise is beautiful, but he doesn't have time to notice it. Quickly flagging down a taxi, while still buttoning his shirt he yells, "Station, *jaldi!*" He pulls up at the station at about 7:15, dashes to the booking counter and breathes a sigh of relief.

He's just about the 10th guy standing in line; his laziness hasn't cost him too much time—he'll only have to wait another hour and a half before the counter opens, and another hour for his turn. By about 10:00 am he's back home and already an hour late to work. "Oh well! It's worth it to finally be able to go on that family vacation after a month."

Some of us will relate to this, others will just laugh in disbelief. The fact still

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remains that this was a reality as little as five or six years ago. Back then, people had three options.

The first was to do exactly as Neeraj did, except that it usually took longer to get tickets. The second was to visit the local travel agent, but you risked getting a wait-listed ticket that would just never seem to get confirmed. The last option was, as all last options usually are, illegal. Buy tickets from a tout, hope and pray they have one for a 50-plus woman, so your mother doesn't have to travel as a

46-year old male, and learn to answer to your assumed name a few days before the journey.

Today, times have changed. The Internet has afforded us the luxury of being able to make it to work on time and use a little of our home or office bandwidth to book our tickets.

Of course, the touts still hover about the station, and the TTE still tries his best to catch those travelling on assumed names, but Neeraj outsmarted the lot. He sat at home on Sunday, surfed the Internet and booked tickets, hotel reservations and even a car with a driver to take his family sightseeing. The Internet is redefining travelling in the country.

Right from giving us a first-hand feel of the destination of choice, to selecting a package deal that fits our budget, the Internet offers everything you need to make your family's vacation memorable.

